DIOCLETIAN'S PALACE

The Succession - rules for four players

Read pages 1 to 3 before the first turn. Use pages 4 to 6 for the succession phase and common questions.

The goal

What you are trying to do

Diocletian has retired. Four rivals prepare a claim to the throne. Collect equipment to become strong, earn Prestige to pay for help, and win the support of two of the three factions in the city. Then stand at the Peristyle, the great crossing of the palace, and proclaim your claim. If none of your three rivals can stop it, the throne is yours.

What you need

- This printed kit: the palace board (four taped pages), the succession map (one page), six treasure cards, the tokens, and one player sheet per person.
- Two ordinary six-sided dice for movement, and one six-sided die for fights (any die works for both - you just need three dice in total).
- A small pawn per player. Coins or buttons work. The paper pawns in this kit also work.
- About 45 to 75 minutes for four players learning the game.

How to set up

1. Assemble the palace board (see the assembly sheet) and lay the succession map beside it; the small map waits until the succession begins. Each player picks a pawn and a player sheet, and writes their name on it.
2. Shuffle the six treasure cards face down. Place one on each treasure entry, the double circles marked A to F. Then turn two of the six face up at random - everyone sees those two treasures from the start.
3. Give each player a random gate: Golden (north), Silver (east), Bronze (south), or Iron (west). Put your pawn on your gate.
4. Choose a starting player at random. The start moves one seat clockwise at the beginning of every round.

DIOCLETIAN'S PALACE - RULES

The Succession

Your turn

One turn, three steps

1. Roll two dice. The total is the maximum number of steps you may take.
2. Move your pawn along the street circles, one circle per step, north, south, east or west. You may stop before using the whole roll and you may pass through circles occupied by other pawns.
3. Do one action where you stand - or do nothing. Taking treasure, standing guard, duelling, gaining support, proclaiming and revealing a district (with the galea) are all actions. You never do two of these on the same turn.

What counts as movement

The white circles are streets. The hatched blocks are buildings: nobody walks through them. All movement and all distances are counted along street circles, not across buildings.

Guard duty and duels are actions of a moving turn: you must move at least one circle first. Taking treasure, gaining support, claiming the checkpoint and proclaiming may be done without moving.

Rounds and turns

A round is one turn for every player, in clockwise order from the starting player. After the last player, a new round begins and the start moves one seat clockwise, so nobody always plays first.

Treasure and equipment

The six treasures

Each treasure entry (double circle, A to F) holds one face-down card: pugio, pilum, galea, scutum, gladius, or lorica segmentata. Two of the six start face up. End your move on an entry to take that card's action: reveal the card to everyone and mark the item on your player sheet.

Every player can collect every item once. The cards stay on the board face up once revealed; they are never taken away, stolen, or lost. If you are the first to stop at an entry, you learn for everyone what waits there.

What each item does

Every item carries one ability that lasts the whole game:

Item	Mark	Ability
Gladius	sword	+1 to your attack in any duel you start
Scutum	shield	+1 to your defense in any duel
Pilum	javelin	+1 to your attack against the standing claimant
Pugio	dagger	you win tied duels
Galea	helmet	once per game, as your action: reveal any one face-down treasure card, wherever it is
Lorica segmentata	armor	once per game: when your claim is beaten, keep your square instead of returning to your gate

In a duel each side adds at most one item bonus - the best one that applies, never a sum. If you hold both the gladius and the pilum and attack the claimant, you still add only +1. Cross an item out on your sheet when its once-per-game ability is used.

Collecting happens only while the palace phase lasts. When the succession begins the palace map leaves the table and your items are fixed - what you hold is what you fight with. Nothing is ever granted for free: if you want an item, walk and get it in time.

Prestige

Earning Prestige

- Guard post (star, palace map only): end a move there and roll one die. A 4, 5 or 6 earns 1 Prestige.
- Win a duel: the winner of any duel earns 1 Prestige. On the succession map this is the only income.

You can hold at most 3 Prestige. Any reward above three is lost - spend it or waste it.

Duels

End your move within two street circles of a rival and you may duel them as your action. The attacker and the defender each roll one die and add their best item bonus for that side. The higher total wins; on a tie the attacker wins - unless exactly one side holds the pugio, whose holder then wins the tie. The winner earns 1 Prestige. The loser pays 1 Prestige to the bank as shame, as much as they hold. Nobody loses equipment or support.

Spending Prestige

- 1 Prestige: one faction's support (next page).
- 1 Prestige: the mandatory fee to contest a proclaimed claim (next page).

Factions and the claim

The three factions

Three groups in the city can back your claim. Their meeting places are marked on the succession map, the small board used for the endgame:

Faction	Badge	Meeting place
Army	shield	east side, on the east-west street
Imperial officials	column	west side, on the east-west street
City elites	laurel	north side, on the north-south street

Visit a meeting place and spend 1 Prestige to gain that faction's support. There is no roll. Every faction can support every player, but each faction supports each player only once. Support lasts the whole game. Meeting places can only be visited during the succession phase - during the palace phase nobody can sell you their backing.

From the city to the succession

The game has two phases and two boards. In the palace phase everyone collects equipment and Prestige on the large board. The first player who owns all six items may stand at the Peristyle and claim the checkpoint as their action. Finish that round, then one more full round, and the succession phase begins. If nobody claims by the end of round 24, the succession begins anyway.

At the change, the palace map leaves the table. Every pawn returns to its gate on the succession map - the same compass gate it started from - and keeps everything it owns: items, Prestige, and any support already gained. From now on all movement, support, duels and claims happen on the small map. Winning a duel is the only Prestige income there - the guard posts stayed behind on the palace map.

Proclaiming a claim

1. During the succession phase, stand at the Peristyle with support from two different factions.
2. Use your action to proclaim your claim. Place the CLAIM marker on the Peristyle. Only one claim can stand at a time.
3. Your claim now stands inside a two-round window. Rivals may cancel it only by winning a challenge duel (next page). Turns that pass without a challenge no longer crown anyone by themselves.
4. If your turn comes while your claim stands and you are still at the Peristyle, you may maintain the claim as your action and stay put. Leaving the Peristyle by your own move cancels your claim.
5. If no rival cancels your claim before two full rounds have passed, you are emperor and the game ends.

Contesting a claim

How to contest

A rival can stop a claim by winning a challenge duel against the claimant. To do it, end your move within two street circles of the claimant and duel them. Challenging a standing claim costs a mandatory fee of 1 Prestige, paid before you roll - even if you lose. Without at least 1 Prestige you cannot contest at all.

The challenge itself is a normal duel: one die each, add your best item bonus, the pugio wins ties. A full challenge costs only the 1 Prestige fee.

What happens on each result

- You win: the claim is canceled. The claimant's pawn returns to their gate on the succession map - unless they have not used the lorica segmentata, which once per game lets a beaten claimant keep their square (the claim still dies). They keep all equipment, Prestige and support either way. The next claim may be proclaimed at any time.
- You lose: the claim stands. Your Prestige is spent either way, and as in any duel the loser pays 1 Prestige shame to the bank.

An example challenge

Livia has proclaimed at the Peristyle with the Army and the elites behind her. Marcus, holding 2 Prestige, the gladius and the pilum, moves next to the crossing. He pays the 1 Prestige fee and duels. His best item bonus is +1 - the pilum also applies against a claimant, but one bonus only counts. He rolls 5 + 1 = 6. Livia holds the scutum and rolls 4 + 1 = 5. Marcus wins; the claim dies and Livia pays 1 Prestige shame. She has kept the lorica segmentata unused, so she stays at the crossing instead of walking back to her gate on the succession map. Marcus earns 1 Prestige for the duel win, leaving him with 2.

If nobody wins

If no claim survives by the end of round 24 of the succession phase, the game ends in a draw - the throne stays empty. This is rare.

Remember

- An ordinary duel is free. Challenging a claim always costs the 1 Prestige fee.
- Everything is public: positions, items, Prestige, support, and who has claimed what. Only the four face-down cards and the next dice roll are hidden.

Common questions

Can I pass through another pawn?
Yes. Pawns never block a street.

Can two pawns share a circle?
Yes, any number may stand on one circle.

Do I have to use my whole roll?
No. Stop anywhere up to the total.

Can I duel the claimant for free while no claim stands?
Yes. Between claims the claimant is an ordinary rival and duels are free.

Can I challenge the same claim twice?
Yes - a failed challenge does not lock you out. Each attempt inside the window pays the fee again.

What if both duelists hold the pugio?
The normal tie rule applies: the attacker wins.

Does the galea let me name an item?
No. You name a district, not an item - the reveal turns up whatever card sits there.

What if I have 3 Prestige and win a guard roll?
Nothing happens - the cap is 3. Spend some first.

Can a faction support two different players?
Yes - every faction can back every player once.

Can I proclaim twice?
Yes, if your first claim is canceled, walk back and proclaim again. Support is never lost.

Can a claim be canceled after the window closes?
No. Two full rounds unchallenged and the game is over.

Do treasures run out?
No. Every player can mark each of the six items.

What if two players reach six items on the same round?
The first to claim at the Peristyle in turn order is the first challenger.

Can we go back to the palace map once the succession begins?
No. The change is one-way: from then on only the succession map is played.

Which gate is mine on the succession map?
The same compass gate you started from - Golden north, Silver east, Bronze south, Iron west.